up the economy, although 1988 officially marked the transition from a socialist economy to a market economy (Turnell 2014a). A key feature of these reforms is that most simply build on law reforms that were introduced post-1988 after the collapse of the socialist regime, extending these reforms a little further. These reforms have reduced the opportunity for individuals to challenge government decisions concerning the application and regulation of licences and permits for various industries in court.

As part of the reform process, some old laws on the economy have been repealed, and this has lifted many restrictions previously used by the military regime to contain and control conflict. For example, the repeal of the 1947 Foreign Exchange Regulation Act and the subsequent decision to float the Kyat in April 2012 was a significant and necessary step forward.[17] This did away with the former discrepancy between the official exchange rate of 6 Kyat to US$1, and the unofficial exchange rate of around 1000 to 1 (see Turnell 2013, 2014a, 2014b). This has attempted to resolve the tension inherent in a system where the unofficial exchange rate was the norm and the official exchange rate benefitted those in power.

One of the first and most significant laws passed in terms of economic reforms was the Foreign Investment Law, passed in 2012 after much debate, followed by a separate law relating to investment by Myanmar citizens.[18] These two laws were combined in 2015, after a more sustained process of public consultation. The Foreign Investment Law seeks to balance the need for certainty and protection of investors' interests with the need to ensure that investment is in the best interests of the country and community. Several issues raise potential for conflict — including tax concessions, land use, and local benefits.

Investors are rewarded with a five-year income-tax break, as well as relief concerning import and export tax. While such tax concessions may be detrimental to local concerns, the law does set a strict standard in terms of labour requirements for skilled positions: twenty-five per cent local employees after five years; fifty per cent after the next five years; and at least seventy-five per cent after the following five years. While this demonstrates acute concern to ensure local Myanmar workers will be appointed to skilled positions, this may be difficult to achieve in practice given the high level of expertise required in some industries.

Another source of tension between government, business, and local communities is that the law grants land use for up to fifty years, with two possible extensions of ten years each. Given that a large number of